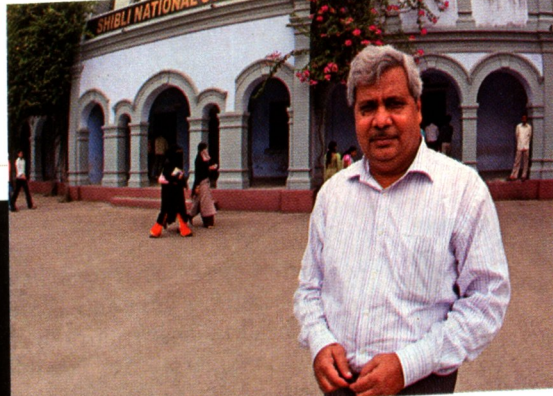


“ There has been little development here. Minority children continue to feel dispossessed. ”

IFTEKAR AHMED, PRINCIPAL, SHIBLI NATIONAL COLLEGE



PAST PERFECT: Entrance to the town's premier cultural landmark, the Shibli National College

to say: “ They (the arrested and killed Jamia students) were not terrorists. Abu Bashir (who was arrested from Azamgarh for “masterminding” the Ahmedabad bombings) is also innocent. It’s the work of Bajrang Dal.”

Azamgarh, with a large Muslim population and little scope for liberal education, is in no mood to abandon its boys “wronged by India”. And the “wronged” community has no time for asking such unpleasant questions like “what went wrong with their boys”. Marked by the ghettos of dispossession and the glitz of Arabian wealth, it supplies leadership to SIMI and other Islamic organisations built on hate. Shahid Badr, a former SIMI leader is now a popular practitioner of unani medicine, but when you meet him in the night in the remoteness of a village called Manshoba, the hakim, seated behind a creaky table full of tablets and discoloured bottles, and a variety of insects (“harmless”) circling above him, he has not lost none of his evangelical fire: “The blasts are conceived by Mossad and CIA, and implemented by Bajrang Dal and RSS. The hands are local. The

brain is foreign. Indian Mujahideen is an IB creation to blackmail the Muslims. And all Muslims should join SIMI. First, I’m Allah *ka banda*, only then I’m a citizen of India.” He takes a pause, and the power goes off. The glow of a lantern magnifies the pleased smile on the hakim’s face, and the room is suddenly filled with the shirtless of Manshoba. “By their actions, Advani and Modi are not Hindus,” he says. Is Osama a Muslim by his action? “Yes.” The hakim is perhaps not talking to you. He has got an audience, among them many teenagers. The preacher is at work, and the lesson is titled hate. For the poorest of Muslim children, education in Azamgarh comes free, though others call it indoctrination.

Elsewhere in the heart of the town, Mohammad Aamir Rashadi, the politically savvy director of one of the main madrasas, Jamiatur Rashad, tells you less fervently: “In India, you cannot be secular.” Translation: Muslims are too religious to be secular. In Azamgarh, someone is always imagining the enemy, whose existence is a necessary condition for the assertion of your religious identity. And someone is always there to kill for it, to die for it.

with Subhash Mishra